



Mohammad Ali Jinnabhai is constantly modified in every retelling; and it is inseparable from the freedom struggle as well as from the human cost of that struggle. It is woven into the bloody tale of Partition, into the evolutionary tragedy of Pakistan. Singh may call his book the first political biography of Jinnah written by "a political figure from India". It tells much more than the extraordinary saga of Jinnah's transformation from an "ambassador of Hindu-Muslim unity, the liberal constitutionalist, the Indian nationalist" to "a Frankenstein monster working to dismember that very world which had so generously created him".

The questions raised in this book are more riveting than the drama of its story. Was Partition inevitable? Was Jinnah alone responsible for the vivisection of India? Why was the idea of a separate Muslim nation a historical fallacy? How far did the political animosity between Jinnah and Jawaharlal Nehru, two ambitious men whose thinking was relatively Western, accelerate the division of India? And why was Gandhi, who wanted Jinnah to lead the interim government, finally such a disillusioned man? His answers in no way idolise the chief engineer of Partition; they nevertheless shatter many cozy assumptions about Independence. When Mountbatten's 'surgical operation' was carried out to meet the demands of Jinnah, it had the assent of Nehru and the Congress Party. "Jinnah did not so much win Pakistan as the Congress leaders—Nehru and Patel finally conceded Pakistan to Jinnah, with

the British acting as an ever helpful midwife." Only one man felt isolated and let down, and that was Gandhi, for whom the Congress party was no longer relevant after freedom had been achieved. For the founder of Pakistan, argues Singh, Partition was a "pragmatic solution with the two-nation theory as a temporary ideological justification"—or the logical end to an argument. For the Indian leaders, especially Nehru, who went along with Jinnah's pragmatism, it was the temptations of power. It could even have been Independence first and then Partition.

Singh is certainly an argumentative storyteller, though his political biography of Quaid-i-Azam is not a what-if historical thriller. He charts the momentous journey of Jinnah—from a Kathiawari household in Karachi to London's Lincoln's Inn to the Bombay High Court to the throbbing centre of national movement to the capital of the liberated Pakistan, while all the time "committed to his three-piece suits, his lorgnette, his cigarette holder and the King's English"—to lead us into a story that is greater than the flaws and fantasies of one man. It is the story of an afterlife, or of the Days After. Post-Partition Pakistan is a chronicle of divisions and dictatorships, of the radicalisation of religion and the repudiation of freedom. In India, politics of minorityism continues to partition the mind. Jinnah's argument cost us so much—in lives and in land. Jaswant Singh's argument reinstates our historical memory—and no nation can afford to lose that.

E X C E R P T

His Barren Attainment

How did Islam with ease first become Indian, then struggled to become a geographical supernumerary to it, to this great spread of what was their own 'home'. From being the faith of kings, emperors and the rulers of India, for a period of time, it then became the faith of the 'separator', of those that divided the land, expelling itself (notionally) from India and moving voluntarily to the eastern and western peripheries of it; relegating such of the faith that remained within India to a life of perpetual self-questioning and doubt about their true identity. For those that 'remained' were then questioned, humiliatingly: 'Where do you actually belong?' These bewildered, abandoned faithful rightly therefore, now

lament—'Are we also not of the *ummah* (an Arabic word which means 'community' or 'nation')?' Besides, what then of the Muslim League's boast of being the 'sole and the exclusive representative of all the faithful'? The League had claimed that it was the true upholder of Islam's ideological authenticity; also of representing a substantive Muslim consensus, therefore, it demanded, rather presupposed, just a single Muslim medium—and asserting its identity as a different conceptual 'nation', claimed a separate land for itself which is why this agonising question continues to grate against our sensibilities: 'Separate' from what? And, what of those that do not so separate 'geographically'? How do you di-